unlikely SP–BSP alliance in UP in 2019, which failed. Perhaps because anti-BJPism, like anti-Congressism before it, sounds good in theory but is likely to work only if the party in question blunders big time—like Rajiv Gandhi did with Bofors—or if the government is overwhelmed by a massive economic crisis. As the psephologist Jai Mrug put it, 'Past experiences in India with the Janata Party and Janata Dal have shown that an alternative built on a purely negative approach is never enduring. The BJP managed to upset the electoral calculus in 1991 not because it was anti-Congress, but it because it offered an alternative vision for India. Ayodhya was the party's cutting edge, its distinctive identity.'[82] The same applies now to the Congress. It cannot just be the not-BJP party. It must offer an alternative vision to differentiate itself.

The BJP's rise as the dominant pillar of Indian polity has given rise to vociferous debates on a whole range of contentious issues: freedom of speech, the future of dissent, the changing nature of federalism, democracy, Centre–state relations, and indeed, on the changing idea of India. These are crucial questions. How they play out will be pivotal for the country's future. Whether you support the BJP or oppose it, it is vital to understand how it grew, its differentiated modes of mobilisation across states and the interface between technology and ideas in today's transformed political and social landscape. This book will be a catalyst, I hope, for new and more informed debates on politics, democracy, technology and the future—in India and elsewhere.